learnt how the pressure brought to bear upon suspects and under-trial prisoners, by the application of various forms of maltreatment, inducements, and undue pressure, risked breaking them and turning them into ‘approvers’ as witnesses on behalf of the state in long drawn-out conspiracy trials. For this reason, the HSRA conducted itself with its cards held close to its chest, disclosing only such information amongst its foot-soldiers as was absolutely necessary. This enabled its members to plausibly deny knowledge of what was actually going on within the HSRA. Nothing demonstrates this better than the testimony of Jai Gopal, who turned ‘approver’ and gave evidence, which eventually convicted Bhagat Singh and his comrades in the Lahore Conspiracy Case. Yet, in his evidence, he could repeatedly do no more than demonstrate his stark ignorance of events when describing how Sukhdev ‘used to keep all the facts concealed’ from him. In fact, as he explained, he was even barred from ‘divulging any secret of the society to Pandit Yashpal’, who ironically as it happened, was himself a prominent member of the HSRA.[7]

The intense secrecy which the HSRA demanded of its members when conducting themselves meant that Bhagat Singh himself also had to adopt many identities, adding further mystery to his persona. In the late 1920s, when he first came into public view following the Dussehra Bomb Case, he was known as ‘Balwant’. Even then, he used several adjectival pen-names when he wrote for newspapers and periodicals, such as ‘*Vidrohi*’ (rebel), ‘*Agyat*’ (unknown) and ‘*Sainik*’ (soldier). So effective was he in camouflaging himself that the director of intelligence in Delhi, who had previously served as senior superintendent of Lahore and who was later on to become the director-general of MI5, had with the most unshakeable conviction been bold enough to declare that there was ‘incontrovertible’ evidence that Bhagat Singh was one by the name of ‘Balraj’, chief of the Hindustan Republican Army. Yet, he was flatly contradicted many decades later by Shiv Verma, a member of the inner circle of the HSRA, who quietly divulged the fact that ‘Balraj’ was actually none other than Chandrashekhar Azad.[8] Such misapprehensions on the part of even the intelligence services were not surprising, though all the more telling for that.